

Credit - Drishti Ias

RPwD Act, 2016: Bridging the Post-18 Disability Support Gap



For Prelims: Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016 , United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities , Unique Disability ID , Sugamya Bharat Abhiyan

For Mains: Challenges faced by PwDs and caregivers, Rights and inclusion of PwDs, Economic and mental-health burden of unpaid caregiving

Source: TH

Why in News?

Nearly a decade after the enactment of the **Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016** , the discourse around disability rights remains largely confined to **basic early education and accessible infrastructure** .

- Ground reports from Keralam expose a critical, unaddressed policy blind spot: the severe systemic vacuum in **post-adulthood institutional support for Persons with Disabilities (PwDs)** , which transfers an unsustainable, **lifelong caregiving burden onto their families** , precipitating deep socio-economic distress.

Summary

- The RPwD Act, 2016 and various schemes provide legal, financial, healthcare, accessibility and rehabilitation support for PwDs, but gaps persist in adult care, social security, employment and independent living.
- India must strengthen respite care, supported living, caregiver support, early intervention, skill development and inter-departmental convergence to reduce the caregiving burden and ensure dignity, inclusion and long-term security for PwDs and their families.

What are the Systemic Challenges Hindering the

Holistic Rehabilitation of PwDs and their Caregivers?

- **Weak Adult Support:** The **RPwD Act, 2016** provides a framework for **inclusion, education and empowerment**, but families continue to face a major support gap after **Class XII and beyond 18 years** .
 - Lack of adequate **adult day-care, assisted living, vocational rehabilitation and supported housing** leaves parents uncertain about their children's future.
- **Caregiver Burden and Economic "Care Penalty":** Existing disability-support systems remain largely **parent-dependent** , with mothers often becoming full-time caregivers.
 - This forces many women to leave **education and employment** , resulting in **income loss, reduced economic independence and social isolation** . Continuous caregiving, sleep deprivation and financial stress can adversely affect **mental health** , increasing the risk of **anxiety, depression and caregiver burnout** .
- **Gaps in Social Security Delivery:** Although **disability pensions and other social-security measures** exist, inadequate awareness, accessibility and last-mile implementation leave eligible families excluded.
- **Exploitation by Unscientific Treatments:** Limited awareness about **early identification, developmental milestones, diagnosis and evidence-based rehabilitation** makes families vulnerable to fraudulent "miracle cures".
 - Such exploitation can result in **asset liquidation, high out-of-pocket expenditure and delayed professional intervention** .
- **Fragmented Implementation of Disability Policies:** Disability rehabilitation involves **Health, Education and Social Justice Departments** , but inadequate inter-departmental convergence creates fragmented service delivery.
- **Inadequate Respite Care for Caregivers:** Parents often lack temporary institutional support when they need to attend to **medical emergencies, employment, travel or other essential responsibilities** .
- **Gender-Specific Vulnerabilities:** Families caring for female PwDs face additional concerns relating to **personal safety, bodily autonomy and menstrual hygiene** .
- **Limited Community-Based and Independent Living Opportunities:** The shortage of **community living facilities, vocational training and supported employment** restricts the ability of persons with intellectual and developmental disabilities to achieve greater self-reliance.
- **Weak Monitoring and Evaluation:** The existence of laws and schemes does not automatically ensure effective rehabilitation , **inadequate audits, weak beneficiary tracking and limited last-mile monitoring** often prevent PwDs from receiving their entitled services.
 - For instance, **ramps may be installed in DTC buses to meet accessibility requirements but remain unused due to poor maintenance, operational gaps or lack of monitoring** , highlighting the gap between **formal accessibility and actual usability** .
 - **Behavioral nudges and awareness campaigns** are needed to promote social acceptance and ensure that available infrastructure is properly used.

India's Disability Framework: Policies and

Initiatives

- **Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016:** The RPwD Act, 2016 replaced the **Persons with Disabilities (Equal Opportunities, Protection of Rights and Full Participation) Act, 1995** . Enacted under **Article 253** of the Indian Constitution, the Act fulfills India's obligations to the **United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD)** , which India ratified in 2007.
 - It recognizes **21 disability categories**, mandates quotas in education and employment, and enforces universal accessibility and non-discrimination.
 - Mandates accessibility in **public buildings, transport, information and communication technology (ICT)** , aligned with the **Sugamya Bharat Abhiyan** .
 - Recognises the **legal capacity and decision-making rights of PwDs** , replacing plenary guardianship with **limited guardianship and supported decision-making** .
 - **Enforcement:** Provides for **Special Courts and penalties** for violations of the rights and dignity of persons with disabilities.
- **National Trust Act, 1999:** Dedicated specifically to the welfare and guardianship of individuals with Autism, Cerebral Palsy, Mental Retardation, and Multiple Disabilities.
- **Rehabilitation Council of India (RCI) Act, 1992:** Regulates training programs and maintains a central register of rehabilitation professionals and special educators.
- **Scheme for Implementation of Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act 2016 (SIPDA):** A central scheme providing technical and financial support to states for implementing the RPwD Act.

Financial, Medical, and Institutional Support

- **Assistance to Disabled Persons for Purchase/Fitting of Aids/Appliances (ADIP):** Provides scientifically manufactured assistive aids, appliances, and funds corrective surgeries (such as cochlear implants) to support independent living.
- **National Divyangjan Finance and Development Corporation (NDFDC):** Set up under the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, it offers concessional loans to promote self-employment through the **Divyangjan Swavalamban Yojana and Vishesh Microfinance Yojana** .
- **Artificial Limbs Manufacturing Corporation of India (ALIMCO):** A non-profit Miniratna enterprise that manufactures and distributes affordable rehabilitation aids nationwide.
- **Deendayal Divyangjan Rehabilitation Scheme (DDRS):** Grants financial assistance to NGOs engaged in the education and rehabilitation of PwDs.

Digital and Accessibility Ecosystem

- **Sugamya Bharat Abhiyan (Accessible India Campaign):** Focuses on universal accessibility across built infrastructure, public transport systems, and information and communication technology (ICT) ecosystem.
- **Sugamya Bharat App (Revamped 2025):** India's digital accessibility hub launched at Purple Fest 2025, featuring accessibility mapping, scheme directories, and direct grievance redressal.
- **Unique ID for Persons with Disabilities (UDID) Scheme:** Creates a centralized national database to issue **Unique Disability Identity Cards**, streamlining government benefits and eliminating duplicate records.

- **PM-DAKSH-DEPwD Portal:** A unified hub for skill development (*Divyangjan Kaushal Vikas*) and private-sector employment linkages (*Divyangjan Rozgar Setu*).
- **PRASHAST App:** A school-level tool for the early screening and identification of disabilities (over 92 lakh students screened).

How Can India Strengthen Support Systems for PwDs and Their Caregivers?

- **Strengthen Adult Care:** Establish **State-supported assisted-living homes, adult day-care centres and supported housing** to address the post-18 support gap. Parent-led community housing models can also be supported through **subsidised land and viability-gap funding** .
- **Institutionalise Respite Care:** Expand **respite-care homes such as Kerala's 'Anpu' Homes** across districts to provide temporary care when caregivers face medical emergencies, travel or personal commitments.
- **Provide Caregiver Support:** Introduce **caregiver allowances, pension support and mental-health counselling** through **District Disability Rehabilitation Centres (DDRCs)** to address the economic and psychological burden of long-term caregiving.
- **Strengthen Early Intervention:** Expand **District Early Intervention Centres (DEICs)** and integrate screening for developmental disabilities into primary and community healthcare for **early diagnosis and timely rehabilitation** .
- **Prevent Exploitative Treatments:** Develop standardised, evidence-based treatment protocols and improve public awareness about **scientifically proven therapies** to protect families from fraudulent “miracle cures” and **excessive out-of-pocket expenditure**.
- **Promote Skill Development and Inclusive Employment:** Introduce **cognitive-vocational mapping** to match PwDs with suitable jobs and encourage companies to adopt **Disability Diversity & Inclusion (D&I) targets or diversity indices** .
 - The government can provide **tax incentives, preferential procurement, ESG-linked benefits or recognition** to companies demonstrating measurable progress in hiring, retaining and creating accessible workplaces for PwDs.
- **Improve Social Security Delivery:** Strengthen disability pensions through better **beneficiary identification, last-mile delivery and grievance redressal** , with pension amounts **linked to inflation and the cost of essential goods and services** .
- **Ensure Inter-Departmental Convergence:** Create stronger coordination among the **Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Ministry of Education and Ministry of Skill Development** to overcome fragmented implementation.
- **Leverage UDID for Lifecycle Support:** Strengthen the **Unique Disability ID (UDID)** system to connect disability certification with **education, rehabilitation, skill development and social-security benefits** .
- **Promote Accessibility and Inclusion:** Expand the **Sugamya Bharat Abhiyan (Accessible India Campaign)** to improve accessibility in **transport, digital services and public infrastructure** .
- **Combat Social Stigma:** Incorporate the lived experiences and rights of PwDs into **school curricula** and strengthen **Community-Based Rehabilitation (CBR)** through Panchayati Raj Institutions and Urban Local Bodies.

Conclusion

India's disability policy must move from **parent-dependent care to a family-centred, life-cycle approach** . Strengthening the implementation of the **RPwD Act, social-security schemes, rehabilitation services, respite care and supported living** , along with better inter-departmental convergence, can ensure **dignity, inclusion and long-term security for both PwDs and their caregivers** .

Drishti Mains Question:

How does the lack of adult-care and supported-living infrastructure shift the burden of disability rehabilitation from the State to families? Suggest suitable reforms.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the RPwD Act, 2016?

It replaced the **Persons with Disabilities Act, 1995** and provides a rights-based framework for **non-discrimination, accessibility, inclusive education and empowerment of PwDs** .

2. What is the National Trust Act, 1999?

It provides welfare and guardianship mechanisms for persons with **autism, cerebral palsy, intellectual disability and multiple disabilities** , particularly those requiring long-term support.

3. What is the UDID Project?

The **Unique Disability ID (UDID)** Project creates a centralised database and disability identity card to facilitate **benefit delivery, identification and access to government schemes** .

4. What is SIPDA?

The **Scheme for Implementation of the RPwD Act (SIPDA)** provides **technical and financial assistance to States** for implementing provisions of the RPwD Act, including accessibility and disability-related infrastructure.

5. What measures can address the post-18 disability support gap?

India needs **adult day-care, assisted living, vocational rehabilitation, respite care and supported independent living** , backed by stronger social security and inter-departmental convergence.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/bNraQ3-dAwk>]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Q. Which of the following statements with regard to the persons with disabilities in India is/are correct? (2026)

1. The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, an Act passed by the Parliament of India in 2018, mandates reservation in education and employment, places a legal duty on Governments to ensure accessibility and non-discrimination.
2. The Sugamya Bharat Abhiyan focuses on achieving universal accessibility for Persons with Disabilities across three key domains: built infrastructure, transport systems and information and communication technology.
3. The National Divyangjan Finance and Development Corporation (NDFDC) is a public sector organisation set up by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs as a not-for-profit company to promote entrepreneurship among Persons with Disabilities (PwDs).

Select the answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 and 2
- (b) 2 only
- (c) 1 and 3
- (d) 1 only

Ans: B

Q. India is home to lakhs of persons with disabilities. What are the benefits available to them under the law? (2011)

1. Free schooling till the age of 18 years in government run schools.
2. Preferential allotment of land for setting up business.
3. Ramps in public buildings.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (d)

Mains

Q. The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 remains only a legal document without intense sensitisation of government functionaries and citizens regarding disability. Comment. (2022)

FSSAI Proposes Front-of-Pack Warning Labels for Packaged Foods



Source: TH

Why in News?

The **Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI)** has tightened regulatory scrutiny over misleading food claims and submitted a proposal to the Supreme Court for **Front-of-Pack Warning Labels (FoPWL)** .

- While these measures aim to **curb deceptive marketing** and promote healthier diets, public health experts have flagged critical loopholes in the proposed warning labels that could allow unhealthy foods to escape scrutiny.

What is FSSAI's Proposal for Warning Labels?

- **Red Hexagonal Warning Symbol:** FSSAI proposed a prominent **red, hexagonal warning symbol** on the front of packaged foods that are **High in Fat, Sugar, and/or Salt (HFSS)** .
- **Specific Declarations:** The labels will read "**High Sugar**", "**High Salt**", "**High Fat**", or "**Highly Sweetened Beverage**" based on nutrient-of-concern thresholds established under the **Dietary Guidelines for Indians, 2024** , issued by the **Indian Council of Medical Research-National Institute of Nutrition (ICMR-NIN)**.
- **Font and Visibility Metric:** The proposed label text is designed to appear in a font size **one point larger** than that used in the nutrition information table on the back of the pack.
- **Phased Implementation:**
 - **Phase I** will cover products high in **two or more** specified nutrients (added fat, added sugar, and salt) and specified sweetened beverages.
 - **Phase II** will extend the warning to products high in **any one** of these nutrients.
- **Exemptions:** Single-ingredient food products and foods inherently rich in fat, sugar, or salt (e.g., ghee, edible oil, salt, sugar, jaggery, and honey) are proposed to be exempted.

Concerns Regarding the Proposed Warning Labels

- **The "Two or More" Nutrients Loophole:** Under Phase I, an item containing dangerously high levels of sugar will not trigger any warning label if its fat and salt levels remain low, and vice versa.
 - Experts argue this completely defeats the core objective of a warning system, which should flag risk based on single-nutrient excess (i.e., *High in Sugar = Warning*).
- **Focus on "Added" Rather than Total Nutrients:** The proposal focuses on "added" saturated fat, sugar, and salt rather than total values.
 - Experts note that ICMR-NIN guidelines set thresholds for total sugar and total fat per 100 grams, and diluting this definition weakens the regulation.

- **Flawed Sizing and Visibility Standard:** Linking label size to back-of-pack nutritional panels (which are often printed in extremely small font sizes) means a one-point increase will remain virtually illegible and fail to catch consumer attention from a shelf distance.
 - Experts demand that warning label size be proportional to the **principal display area** of the package.
- **Absence of Multilingual Warnings:** The current plan lacks explicit requirements for prominent bilingual warnings (Hindi, English, and regional languages), limiting accessibility across diverse demographic groups.
- **Vague Timelines:** The affidavit does not outline strict, binding timelines for transitioning from Phase I to Phase II.
- **Penalties Remain Weak:** The **Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006** , prescribes a maximum fine of Rs 3 lakh for misbranding or false labelling.
 - Critics argue this financial penalty is negligible compared to the massive commercial gains achieved through aggressive and misleading advertising.

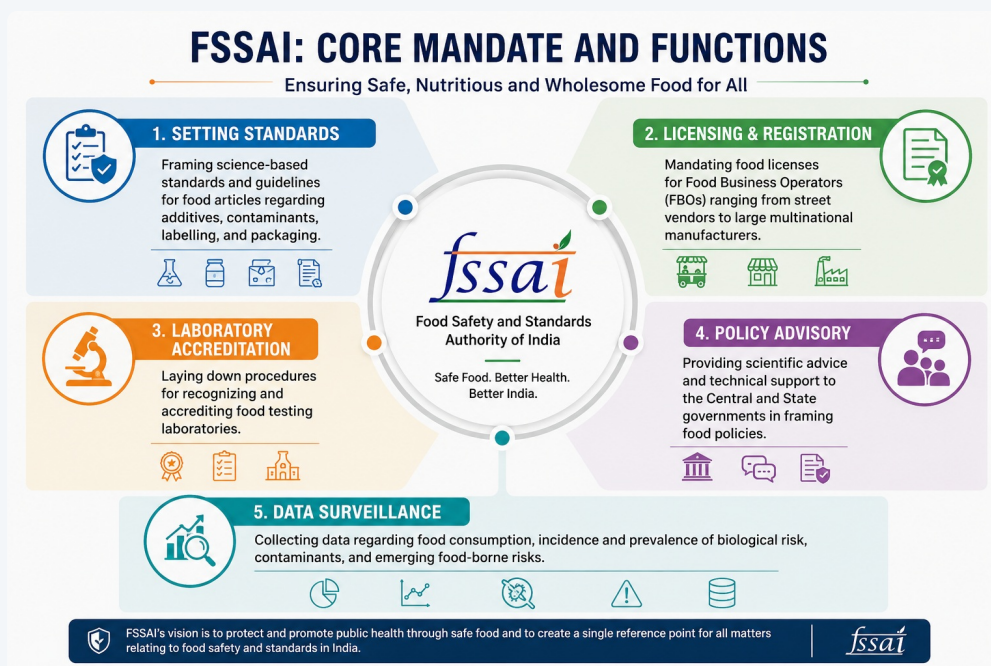
Supreme Court Push for Mandatory Front-of-Pack Warning Labels

- **Long-Pending Reform:** FSSAI has been working on front-of-pack labelling since **2018** . Its 2022 draft proposed a **Health Star Rating** , but the proposal faced opposition and remained unimplemented.
- **Supreme Court Intervention:** The Court stepped in following a petition by public health groups, stressing that consumers need **clear front-of-pack warnings** to identify foods high in **sugar, salt and unhealthy fats** .
 - It linked this need to the **Right to Health under Article 21** , particularly for protecting children from obesity and other non-communicable diseases.
- **FSSAI's New Proposal:** Following the Court's ultimatum, FSSAI submitted a compliance affidavit, proposing a **red hexagonal warning label** on packaged foods high in **fat, sugar or salt** .
 - The Supreme Court will review the proposed framework on 10 th **September 2026** .

Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI)

- **Established:** Under the **Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006** .
- **Nodal Ministry:** **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW)** .
- **Unified Framework:** The Act consolidated several food laws, including the **Prevention of Food Adulteration Act, 1954** , Fruit Products Order, Meat Food Products Order, and Milk and Milk Products Order.
- **Composition:** **Chairperson + 22 members** , with at least **one-third women** .
- **Representation:** Includes stakeholders from the food **industry, agriculture, commerce, consumer affairs, farmers and state regulators** .

- **Scientific Support:** Scientific Panels/Committees help set food standards, while the **Central Advisory Committee** coordinates with state enforcement agencies.



Key Initiatives and Campaigns

Initiative	Objective & Details
Eat Right India Movement	A flagship campaign aligned with the National Health Policy to ensure safe, healthy, and sustainable food for all. Focuses on reducing salt, sugar, and fat intake.
State Food Safety Index (SFSI)	An annual index that measures the performance of Indian states across five parameters of food safety (Human Resources, Compliance, Testing Infra, Training, Consumer Empowerment).
RUCO (Repurpose Used Cooking Oil)	Promotes the collection and conversion of used cooking oil (which contains harmful Total Polar Compounds) into biodiesel, preventing its reentry into the food chain.
Clean Street Food Hub / BHOG	Raising hygiene standards among unorganized street vendors. BHOG (Blissful Hygienic Offering to God) ensures safe food practices at places of worship.
Food Safety Compliance System (FoSCoS)	A pan-India, cloud-based IT platform replacing the older system (Food Licensing and Registration System (FLRS)) to issue licenses and monitor compliance efficiently.
Heart Attack Rewind	A mass-media campaign explicitly designed to eliminate industrially produced trans-fats in the food supply by 2022.

What Measures are Needed to Strengthen India's

Front-of-Pack Warning Labelling Framework?

- **Adopt a Single-nutrient Trigger:** A warning should be mandatory when **any one nutrient** such as sugar, salt or fat exceeds the prescribed threshold, rather than requiring multiple nutrients to be high.
- **Use Total Nutrient Content:** Align thresholds with the **ICMR-NIN Dietary Guidelines (2024)** and **WHO SEARO Nutrient Profile Model** , using **total sugars and fats** to minimise analytical loopholes.
- **Ensure Prominent Warnings:** Red hexagonal warnings should occupy a fixed proportion of the **Principal Display Area (PDA)** rather than being only marginally larger than the nutrition table.
- **Restrict Child-targeted Marketing:** Products carrying warnings should not use **cartoon characters, toys or child-directed endorsements** on packaging.
 - Restrict the **sale and advertising of products carrying FoP warnings in and around educational institutions** .
- **Promoting Health Literacy:** Conduct nationwide awareness campaigns on **FoPNL and hidden sugar** , complemented by **CBSE’s ‘sugar boards’ initiative across 24,000+ affiliated schools** to curb excessive sugar consumption among children.

Global Best Practices

Best Practice Model	Country / Region	Core Approach
Negative Warning Signs	Chile, Mexico, Peru	Mandatory black octagons / stop-signs for High Sugar, Salt, & Saturated Fat
Visual Magnifier Warnings	Brazil	High-contrast magnifying glass highlighting critical excess nutrients
Evaluative Color-Coding	UK (Traffic Light)	Red/Amber/Green grading to guide healthier consumer choices
Positive Incentive & Efficacy	Japan	Scientifically vetted front-of-pack health seals & ultra-precise allergen safety thresholds

Drishti Mains Question:

“Front-of-pack warning labels can transform food labelling from information disclosure into a public-health intervention.” Discuss

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is FSSAI and under which law was it established?

FSSAI was established under the **Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006** and functions under the **Ministry of Health and Family Welfare** .

2. What is FSSAI's proposed Front-of-Pack Warning Label?

It is a **red hexagonal warning symbol** indicating products high in **sugar, salt or fat** , with specific declarations such as "High Sugar" or "High Salt."

3. What is the major concern with Phase I of the proposed FoPWL framework?

Phase I requires products to be high in **two or more specified nutrients** , potentially allowing foods excessively high in a single nutrient to escape warnings.

4. What are the major initiatives of FSSAI for food safety?

Key initiatives include **Eat Right India, State Food Safety Index, RUCO, Clean Street Food Hub, BHOG, FoSCoS and Heart Attack Rewind** .

5. What measures can strengthen India's FoPWL framework?

Adopt a **single-nutrient trigger** , use total nutrient content, ensure warnings occupy a fixed **Principal Display Area** , restrict child-targeted marketing and improve **health literacy** .

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/4L6PKkMnkAE](https://www.youtube.com/embed/4L6PKkMnkAE)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following statements: (2018)

1. The Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 replaced the Prevention of Food Adulteration Act, 1954.
2. The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) is under the charge of Director General of Health Services in the Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (a)

Q. With reference to the provisions made under the National Food Security Act, 2013, consider the following statements: (2018)

1. The families coming under the category of 'below poverty line (BPL)' only are eligible to receive subsidised food grains.
2. The eldest woman in a household, of age 18 years or above, shall be the head of the household for the purpose of issuance of a ration card.
3. Pregnant women and lactating mothers are entitled to a 'take-home ration' of 1600 calories per day during pregnancy and for six months thereafter.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 3 only

Ans: (b)

Mains:

Q. Elaborate the policy taken by the Government of India to meet the challenges of the food processing sector. (2021)

Per Drop More Crop



Why in News?

The Government highlighted the progress of **Per Drop More Crop (PDMC)** , a **micro-irrigation scheme aimed at improving water use efficiency and agricultural productivity** through efficient irrigation practices.

- As of July 2026, PDMC has brought over 115 lakh hectares under micro-irrigation coverage, with **DBT-based financial assistance** and digital implementation improving transparency, farmer access, and adoption of resource-efficient agriculture.

What are the Key Facts About Per Drop More Crop?

- **About:** The **Per Drop More Crop (PDMC) scheme** promotes efficient water use at the farm level through micro-irrigation systems such as **drip irrigation and sprinkler irrigation** . It is a **Centrally Sponsored Scheme** aimed at improving water use efficiency and agricultural productivity by delivering water directly to crops with minimum losses.
- **Evolution of the Scheme:** The initiative **began in January 2006 as the Centrally Sponsored Scheme** for Micro Irrigation.
 - It was upgraded to the National Mission on Micro Irrigation (NMMI) in 2010–11.
 - During FY 2014–15, it became part of the **National Mission on Sustainable Agriculture (NMSA)** under the **On Farm Water Management (OFWM) component**.
 - From 2015–16 to 2021–22, it was implemented as Per Drop More Crop (PDMC) under the **Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana (PMKSY)** .
 - Since 2022–23, PDMC has been implemented under the **Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (PM-RKVVY)** .
- **Financial Assistance for Micro-Irrigation:** Under PDMC, farmers receive financial support for installing micro-irrigation systems up to **5 hectares per beneficiary** .
 - **Small and marginal farmers receive 55% assistance** , while other farmers receive **45% assistance** . A total of **₹8,123.24 crore** of central assistance has been released during the last three years.
- **Need for Water Efficiency:** Agriculture **consumes more than 80% of India's available water resources**, while only around **50% of the net sown area** has irrigation facilities.
 - PDMC addresses this challenge by **promoting micro-irrigation, which improves water use efficiency, reduces water losses, and supports sustainable agricultural production** .

Progress in Scaling Micro-Irrigation across India through PDMC

- **Expansion of Micro-Irrigation Coverage:** Since its inception, PDMC has brought around **115 lakh hectares** under micro-irrigation (as of July 2026), covering nearly **8.11% of India's net sown area** .
- **Leading States and Beneficiaries:** During **2025-26** , **Maharashtra, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, and Rajasthan** recorded the highest area coverage under PDMC. The scheme

benefited around **12.30 lakh farmers** , with **nearly 20% women beneficiaries** .

- **Promotion of Water Conservation:** New flexibilities under PDMC allow States and UTs to undertake **micro-level water storage and conservation activities** , including the construction of **diggis (farm ponds/storage tanks)** and water harvesting systems under the **“Other Interventions”** component .
- **Flexible Funding Approach:** Earlier, expenditure on water conservation activities was limited to **20% of total allocation for general States/UTs** and **40% for North-Eastern and Himalayan States and J&K and Ladakh** . Revised guidelines now allow States and UTs to **exceed these limits based on local requirements** .



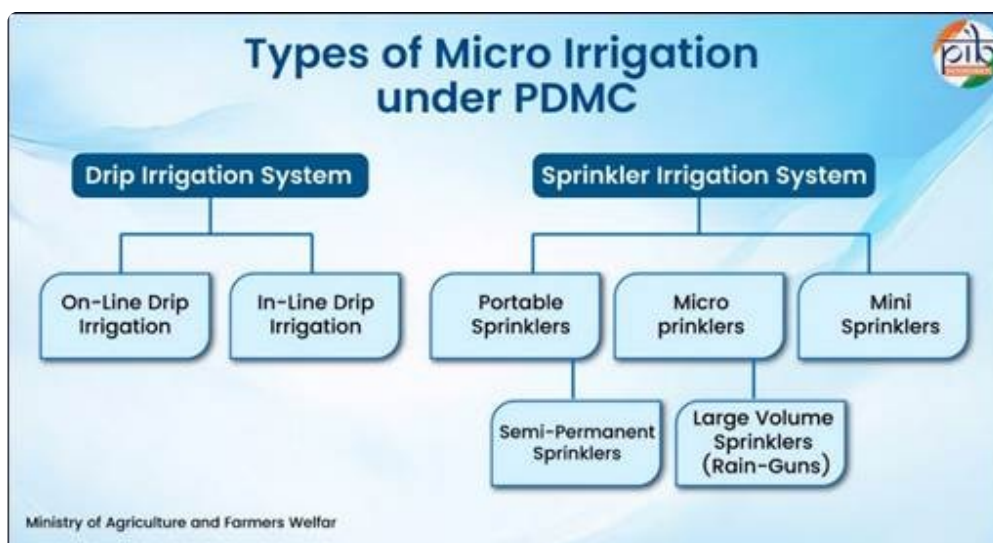
Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (PM-RKVY)

- **Umbrella Agriculture Development Scheme:** Launched in **2007-08** , RKVY was restructured as **PM-RKVY in October 2024** to promote sustainable agriculture and allied sector development by merging **nine schemes** , including **PDMC, agricultural mechanisation, soil health management, crop diversification, and agri-startup support** .
- **State Flexibility:** PM-RKVY provides greater flexibility to states by allowing them to **reallocate funds among components according to local agricultural priorities** and emerging challenges such as climate resilience and value-chain development.
- **Funding Support:** During **2025-26** , a total of **₹8,957.72 crore** was released/sanctioned under PM-RKVY, including **₹3,226.36 crore specifically for PDMC** .

What are the Types of Micro Irrigation Systems under PDMC?

Drip Irrigation System

- **About:** Drip irrigation supplies water **slowly and directly to the plant root zone** through emitters fitted on lateral tubes, ensuring efficient water use and reducing wastage.
- **On-Line Drip System:** In this system, separate drippers are installed along the pipe at the location of individual plants, making it suitable for **crops with irregular spacing** .
- **In-Line Drip System:** In this system, emitters are already built into the pipe at fixed intervals, providing **uniform water distribution** to regularly spaced plants.



Sprinkler Irrigation System

- **About:** Sprinkler irrigation distributes water under pressure through nozzles attached to a pipe network, creating an effect similar to rainfall and ensuring uniform irrigation. It is mainly used for **high-density**

crops, cereals, pulses, seeds, spices, and field crops .

- **Portable Sprinklers:** These systems have movable main and sub-main pipes, allowing irrigation at different locations based on crop requirements and suitability for both plains and uneven terrains.
- **Micro Sprinklers:** These are low-radius sprinklers mainly used for **leafy vegetables, nurseries, and seedling development** . They also help regulate the micro-climate around plants.
- **Mini Sprinklers:** These are used for closely spaced crops such as **groundnut, potato, onion, ginger, and short-stature fodder crops** and can also provide frost protection.
- **Semi-Permanent Sprinklers:** In this system, main and lateral pipes are permanently installed underground, while sprinkler nozzles can be shifted through riser pipes for targeted irrigation.
- **Large Volume Sprinklers (Rain-Guns):** These high-pressure sprinklers cover large areas in a short time and are suitable for **large-scale field irrigation** , with a discharge capacity of around **10,000-32,000 litres per hour** .



What are the Focus Areas and Implementation Framework of PDMC?

Focus Areas of PDMC

- **Precision Water Management:** PDMC promotes **efficient and precise use of irrigation water** through micro-irrigation systems to improve crop productivity and enhance farmers' incomes.
- **Fertigation Support:** The scheme encourages **fertigation** , which involves applying fertilizers along with irrigation water directly to the root zone, improving **nutrient-use efficiency** and reducing wastage.
- **Priority to Water-Stressed Regions:** PDMC focuses on **water-scarce and groundwater-stressed areas** to promote sustainable water management in agriculture.
- **Integration with Irrigation Systems:** The scheme supports the integration of micro-irrigation with **tube wells, river-lift irrigation, and solar-powered irrigation systems** for better water resource utilisation.

- **Technology and Convergence:** PDMC promotes **scientific advancements in micro-irrigation technology** and encourages convergence with other government programmes to maximise water-use efficiency.



Implementation Framework of PDMC

- **National-Level Governance:** Since PDMC is implemented under **Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (PM-RKVY)**, it follows its institutional framework. The **National Stewardship Council (NSC)** provides strategic guidance, planning support, and overall direction.
- **State-Level Implementation:** At the state level, the scheme follows a three-tier mechanism. The **State Level Sanctioning Committee (SLSC)** approves state plans, while the **Inter-Departmental Working Group (IDWG)** coordinates implementation among different departments.
- **District-Level Execution:** The **District Level Implementation Committee (DLIC)** supervises ground-level execution and ensures coordination among various departments for effective implementation.

Impact Assessment of PDMC

- **NITI Aayog Evaluation (2020-21):** PDMC enhances water-use efficiency, **improves crop productivity, generates employment opportunities**, and increases farmers' incomes, with beneficiaries reporting 10%–69% income improvement and 30%–70% gains in water-use efficiency.
- **Resource Savings Through Micro-Irrigation:** The **Economic Survey 2020-21** reported that micro-irrigation resulted in **20%–48% water savings, 10%–17% energy savings, 30%–40% reduction in labour costs, and 11%–19% fertilizer savings**.
- **Improved Agricultural Productivity:** Micro-irrigation practices were associated with **20%–38% increase in crop yields**, enhancing farm productivity and profitability.
- **IIMA Study (2023):** A study by the **Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad (IIMA)** across six states found that farmers adopted micro-irrigation mainly to address **groundwater decline, meet crop-specific water requirements, and achieve long-term agricultural benefits**.

Conclusion

The **Per Drop More Crop (PDMC)** scheme represents a major shift from traditional irrigation practices towards **precision and resource-efficient agriculture** . By promoting drip and sprinkler irrigation, the scheme improves water-use efficiency, reduces input costs and enhances farmers' incomes. With over **115 lakh hectares under micro-irrigation** , PDMC has emerged as a crucial initiative for sustainable agricultural development.

Drishti Mains Question

Micro-irrigation is essential for achieving sustainable agricultural growth in India. Discuss the role of the Per Drop More Crop scheme in improving water-use efficiency and farmer incomes.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is Per Drop More Crop (PDMC)?

PDMC is a government scheme that promotes micro-irrigation technologies such as drip and sprinkler irrigation to improve water-use efficiency and agricultural productivity.

2. Under which scheme is PDMC currently implemented?

PDMC is currently implemented under the **Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (PM-RKVY)**.

3. What are the two major micro-irrigation systems supported under PDMC?

The two major systems are Drip irrigation and Sprinkler irrigation.

4. What subsidy is provided under PDMC?

Small and marginal farmers receive **55% financial assistance** and Other farmers receive **45% financial assistance** .

5. What is fertigation?

Fertigation is the process of applying fertilizers through irrigation water directly to the plant root zone.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/ZxJRmENdzV8>]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions

Prelims

Q. With reference to micro-irrigation, which of the following statements is/are correct? (2011)

1. Fertilizer/nutrient loss can be reduced.
2. It is the only means of irrigation in dryland farming.
3. In some areas of farming, receding of ground water table can be checked.

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (c)

Mains

Q. What are the major challenges faced by the Indian irrigation system in recent times? State the measures taken by the government for efficient irrigation management. (2024)

Q. How and to what extent would micro-irrigation help in solving India's water crisis? (2021)

Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Government highlighted the achievements of the **Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY)**, a crop insurance scheme providing coverage against **natural calamities, pests, diseases, prevented sowing, localized calamities, and specified post-harvest losses**.

- With **₹12,200 crore allocated for 2026-27**, PMFBY continues to strengthen **farmer resilience, income stability, and climate-resilient agriculture**.

What are the Key Facts About PMFBY?

- **About:** The **Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY)** was launched on **18th February 2016** to provide affordable crop insurance coverage to farmers and protect them against crop losses due to natural calamities and production risks.
- **Premium Structure:** PMFBY ensures affordable crop insurance by limiting farmer contributions to **2% for Kharif and 1.5% for Rabi foodgrain and oilseed crops**, while commercial and horticultural crops attract a maximum premium of **5%**.
 - The remaining premium is shared by the **Central and State Governments in a 50:50 ratio**, with a **90:10 subsidy ratio for North-Eastern and Himalayan States**.

Risk Coverage

- **Types:** PMFBY covers crop losses from **pre-sowing risks (prevented or failed sowing), standing crop losses due to natural calamities, localized calamities, and post-harvest losses** caused by events such as cyclones and unseasonal rainfall.
- **Yield Loss Coverage:** PMFBY provides area-based insurance against non-preventable risks such as **drought, floods, inundation, cyclones, hailstorms, lightning, pests and diseases** affecting standing crops.
- **Prevented Sowing:** Farmers who incur cultivation expenses but are unable to sow due to adverse weather conditions are eligible for claims of up to **25% of the sum insured**.
- **Post-Harvest Losses:** Crops kept in **cut-and-spread condition for drying after harvesting** are covered for up to **14 days** against specified events such as **cyclones and unseasonal rainfall**.
- **Localized Calamities:** Individual farm-level losses caused by **hailstorms, landslides, inundation, cloudbursts and natural fires** are covered under specified conditions.
- **Excluded Risks:** PMFBY does not cover losses caused by **war, nuclear risks, riots, theft, negligence, preventable risks, and specified post-harvest conditions**.

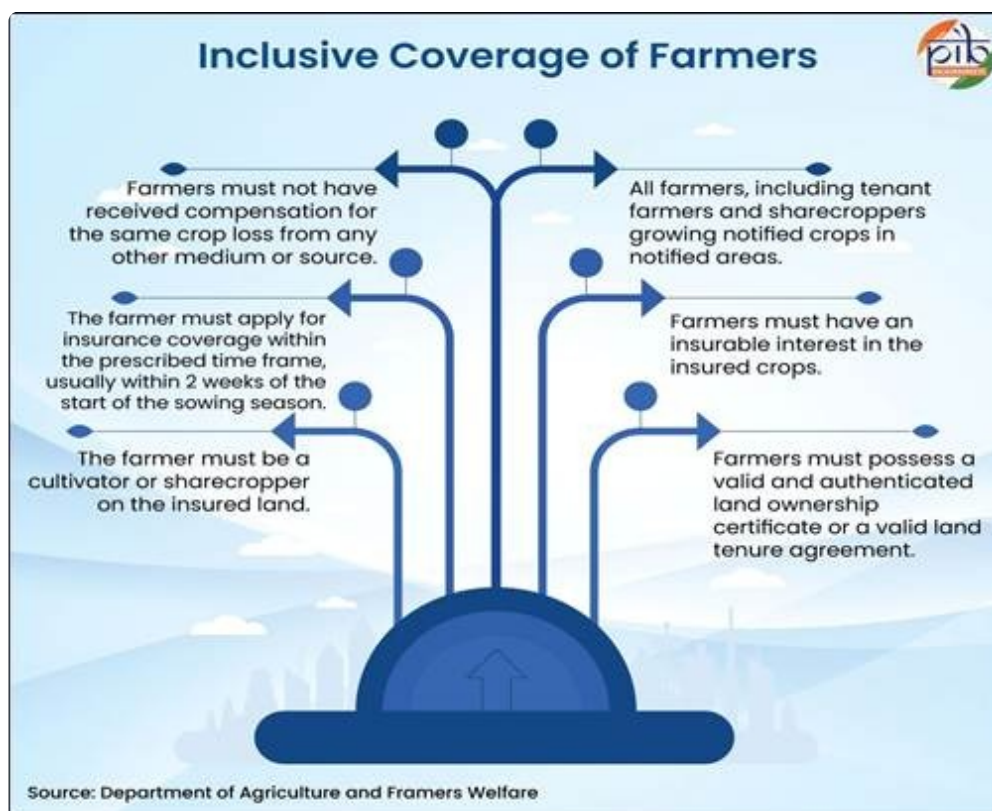


Inclusive Coverage of Farmers

- **Categories:** PMFBY provides insurance coverage to **loanee farmers, non-loanee farmers, tenant**

farmers and sharecroppers , subject to prescribed eligibility conditions and submission of valid land or cultivation documents.

- **Non-Loanee Farmers:** Farmers who do not avail crop loans can **voluntarily enrol** under PMFBY. Over the last decade, around **50% of enrolled farmers on average have been non-loanee farmers** , indicating growing participation in voluntary crop insurance.
- **Loanee Farmers:** Farmers availing **seasonal crop loans or active Kisan Credit Card (KCC) -linked loans** are covered under PMFBY, with premiums deducted by banks from the loan amount.
- **Eligibility Conditions:** Farmers must have an **insurable interest, valid land documents/tenure agreements or sowing certificates** , and must apply within the specified period to receive coverage.



Progress and Achievements Under PMFBY

- **Wider State-Level Implementation:** PMFBY is currently being implemented in **25 States and Union Territories during Kharif 2026** , reflecting its broad institutional reach across the country.
- **Large-Scale Insurance Coverage:** Since its launch, PMFBY has insured more than **92.46 crore farmer applications** , while over **26.33 crore farmer applications have received claims exceeding ₹2.06 lakh crore** , providing financial support against crop losses.
- **Record Enrolment in 2024-25:** The scheme achieved its highest-ever enrolment in **2024-25** , with more than **15.23 crore farmer applications** , covering over **4 crore farmers** and **623 lakh hectares of agricultural land** .
- **Inclusion of Tenant and Sharecropper Farmers:** PMFBY also extends coverage to **tenant and sharecropper farmers** .

What are the Key Government Initiatives to Strengthen PMFBY Implementation?

- **National Crop Insurance Portal (NCIP):** The **NCIP provides a digital platform** for farmer enrolment, subsidy management, coordination among stakeholders, and dissemination of crop

- insurance-related information. It also enables access to insured farmer details, automated claim calculation, and **direct electronic transfer of insurance claims into farmers' bank accounts** .
- **Integration of Land Records with NCIP:** The integration of **state e-land records with NCIP** helps validate insured land parcels, insured areas, and farmer details. Digital land record validation is being implemented in **Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Karnataka, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, and Odisha** , covering around **85% of insured areas** in these States.
 - **Digicloud Module:** Introduced in **Kharif 2022** , the **Digicloud module** enables transparent calculation, processing, and settlement of crop insurance claims through NCIP.
 - Claims are transferred through the **Public Finance Management System (PFMS)** , allowing end-to-end monitoring up to the farmer level. More than **₹55,000 crore in claims** have been calculated and paid through this digital platform.
 - **CCE-Agri App:** The **Crop Cutting Experiment (CCE)-Agri App** enables digital recording and uploading of crop yield data on NCIP. This data is used to calculate actual yield and determine eligible insurance claims, while allowing insurance companies to monitor CCEs, improving **transparency, accuracy, and timely claim settlement** .

Digital Innovations Strengthening Crop Insurance Delivery

- **YES-TECH (Yield Estimation System Based on Technology):** Uses **remote sensing and technology-based methods** for accurate crop yield estimation. Introduced for **paddy and wheat in Kharif 2023 and soybean in Kharif 2024** , its yield estimates now contribute up to **50% weightage in certain States** .
- **WINDS (Weather Information Network and Data System):** Uses **Automatic Weather Stations and Automatic Rain Gauges** to provide hyperlocal weather data at **Block and Gram Panchayat levels** , supporting weather-based insurance, yield estimation, disaster management and forecasting.
- **CROPIC (Collection of Real-time Photos and Observations of Crops):** Uses **geo-tagged crop photographs** to monitor crop health and support future crop damage assessment and yield estimation through image-based analytics.
- **Krishi Rakshak Portal & Helpline (KRPH):** Provides a **toll-free helpline (14447)** for farmers to register and track crop insurance grievances. Since its launch in **January 2024** , it has resolved **26.12 lakh grievances with a 99.66% resolution rate** .
- **Digital Tools for Enrolment and Claims:** The **Learning Management System (LMS)** improves stakeholder awareness, while **AIDE (App for Intermediary Enrolment)** enables doorstep enrolment of non-loanee farmers and **CLAP (Crop Loss Assessment App)** supports faster and transparent assessment of localized crop losses.

Restructured Weather-Based Crop Insurance Scheme (RWBCIS)

- **Weather-Based Insurance Mechanism:** RWBCIS provides insurance against **weather-related risks** by using weather parameters as a **proxy for crop damage** instead of assessing actual yield losses. Claims are triggered when weather conditions deviate from predefined thresholds.
- **Coverage Parameters:** The scheme considers factors such as **excess or deficit rainfall, dry spells, extreme temperature, humidity, and wind speed** recorded through notified weather stations. States/UTs may also provide additional coverage for localized risks like **hailstorms and cloudbursts** .
- **Area-Based Implementation:** RWBCIS operates through **Reference Unit Areas (RUAs)** , where crop-wise weather indices determine payouts. The crop cycle is divided into different phases, with the sum

insured allocated according to crop vulnerability.

- **Premium and Coverage:** The scheme follows the same affordable premium structure as PMFBY (**1.5% for Rabi, 2% for Kharif foodgrain/oilseed crops and up to 5% for commercial and horticultural crops**). It is particularly beneficial for **fruit, vegetable, and plantation crops** .

Conclusion

The **Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana** has emerged as a major pillar of India's agricultural risk management framework. By providing affordable insurance coverage against climate-related and production risks, the scheme has strengthened farmer resilience and income security. As India moves towards **climate-resilient agriculture** , PMFBY will remain crucial in protecting farmers, ensuring food security and building a sustainable agricultural economy.

Drishti Mains Question

Climate change has increased uncertainty in Indian agriculture. Discuss the role of Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana?

PMFBY is a crop insurance scheme launched in 2016 to provide financial protection to farmers against crop losses caused by natural calamities, pests, diseases and adverse weather events.

2. What premium is paid by farmers under PMFBY?

Farmers pay 2% for Kharif foodgrain and oilseed crops, 1.5% for Rabi foodgrain and oilseed crops and 5% for commercial and horticultural crops.

3. What is YES-TECH?

YES-TECH is a technology-based yield estimation system using remote sensing and scientific methods to improve crop yield assessment and claim settlement.

4. What is WINDS under PMFBY?

WINDS collects hyperlocal weather data through Automatic Weather Stations and Rain Gauges to support weather-based insurance and agricultural risk assessment.

5. What is the maximum claim under prevented sowing?

Farmers can receive claims up to **25% of the sum insured** for prevented sowing.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/tPaE1d5cvtU>

]

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. With reference to 'Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana', consider the following statements: (2016)

1. Under this scheme, farmers will have to pay a uniform premium of two percent for any crop they cultivate in any season of the year.
2. This scheme covers post-harvest losses arising out of cyclones and unseasonal rains.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. Given the vulnerability of Indian agriculture to vagaries of nature, discuss the need for crop insurance and bring out the salient features of the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY) (2016)

Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope



Source: TH

The **Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope** is **NASA's** next-generation flagship space observatory designed to explore major mysteries of the universe, including **dark energy** , **dark matter** , cosmic expansion, gravitational physics , and **exoplanets** .

- **About:** It is named after **Nancy Grace Roman, NASA's first Chief Astronomer** , who played a key role in developing NASA's space astronomy programme and is often called the **"Mother of the Hubble Space Telescope."**
 - The mission will complement the capabilities of the **Hubble Space Telescope (launched in 1990)** and the **James Webb Space Telescope (launched in 2021)** by conducting wider and deeper surveys of the universe.
- **Launch and Location:** The approximately **\$4 billion mission** was launched aboard a SpaceX Falcon Heavy rocket from Kennedy Space Center, Florida and will operate near the Sun-Earth **Lagrange Point 2 (L2)** , about **1.6 million km from Earth** .
 - Roman will **survey the universe around 1,000 times faster than Hubble and generate around 1.4 terabytes of data daily**, using AI and machine learning for data analysis.
- **Advanced Observation Capability:** Equipped with a **300-megapixel Wide Field Instrument (infrared camera)**, Roman will survey vast regions of space, study over two billion galaxies, and examine the evolution of cosmic structures.
 - The telescope will measure **how the universe has expanded over time and investigate the role of dark energy** in shaping cosmic evolution.
- **Exoplanet Exploration:** Using a **coronagraph instrument** that blocks the intense light of stars, Roman will directly observe **exoplanets and planet-forming disks** . It will also conduct a statistical survey of **planetary systems in the Milky Way** .
- **Major Contribution:** Roman will provide insights into **galaxy evolution, dark matter, dark energy, gravitational physics, and planetary systems** , with contributions from international partners including **ESA** , **JAXA** , **CNES** , and the **Max Planck Institute for Astronomy** .

Read More: [James Webb Space Telescope](#)

Rights of the Accused to Access an FIR



Source:TH

The Supreme Court reaffirmed the **Youth Bar Association of India v. Union of India (2016)** guidelines, highlighting the gap between criminal law and judicial safeguards on an accused's **right to timely First Information Report (FIR) access for a fair trial** .

- **Statutory Void in BNSS:** The new **Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 (BNSS)** does not expressly mandate the police to furnish an FIR to the accused immediately upon registration.
 - **Section 173(2) of the BNSS does not expressly provide for supplying a copy of the FIR to the accused.** It primarily deals with providing the FIR to the **informant or victim** .
 - **Section 230 of the BNSS** requires the Magistrate to furnish the accused with copies of the **FIR and other relevant documents** after cognizance and within the prescribed stage of proceedings.
- **Youth Bar Association Case, 2016:** The Supreme Court directed that FIRs should generally be **uploaded on police websites within 24 hours** of registration (extendable to 48-72 hours for geographical/connectivity issues).
 - An accused or their representative can apply for a **certified copy from the police, which must be supplied within 24 hours** , or from the jurisdictional magistrate within two working days.
- **The 'Sensitive Offence' Exemption:** FIRs related to **sexual offences, the POCSO Act** , and **terror offences are exempted from mandatory online publication** to protect privacy.
- **Protocol for Exemption:** Withholding an FIR requires a reasoned decision by an officer **not below the rank of Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP)** . Even in these cases, the **magistrate must promptly provide a copy to the accused within three days** of application.
- **Systemic Failures:** **CCTNS (Crime and Criminal Tracking Network & Systems)** is the police database through which FIRs are made publicly accessible, but compliance with the Supreme Court's uploading requirement remains uneven.
- **Impact on Fundamental Rights:** Denying an accused early access to the FIR obstructs their ability to pursue **pre-trial remedies like anticipatory bail or quashing of proceedings** , fundamentally undermining the **right to a fair trial and the principles of natural justice** .

Read more: [FIR and General Diary](#)

Ramon Magsaysay Awards 2026



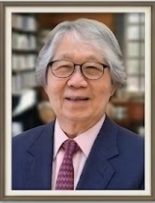
The **Ramon Magsaysay Award Foundation** announced the winners of the **Ramon Magsaysay Awards 2026** , honouring three Asian personalities for their outstanding contributions to society. The awardees include **Tommy Koh (Singapore)** , **Runa Khan (Bangladesh)** and **Bo Kyi (Myanmar)** .

Ramon Magsaysay Award

- **About:** The Ramon Magsaysay Award, **established in 1958** , honors individuals and organizations that have made significant contributions to **human development** in Asia and globally, addressing complex societal issues.
 - The Ramon Magsaysay Award is considered one of Asia’s most prestigious honours and is often referred to as **“Asia’s Nobel Prize.”**
 - Awardees are selected annually by the **Ramon Magsaysay Award Foundation (RMAF)** and receive a medallion, certificate, and cash prize.
- **Objective:** The Award was created to recognize selfless service and the greatness of spirit, irrespective of **race, gender, or religion**, and celebrates transformative leadership and courage in Asia.
- **Categories:** From 1958 to 2008, the Award was given in **six categories**: Government Service, Public Service, Community Leadership, Journalism, Literature & Creative Communication Arts, Peace & International Understanding, and Emergent Leadership (for individuals 40 years of age or younger).
 - Since 2009, the Award no longer follows fixed categories, except for Emergent Leadership, which continues with support from the **Ford Foundation**.

RAMON MAGSAYSAY AWARDEES: PIONEERS OF CHANGE

TOMMY KOH (SINGAPORE)



- **Diplomat and Lawyer** (Age: 88)
- Recognized for promoting **International Dialogue** and the **Rule of Law**.
- **UN Conference on the Law of the Sea (1982)**: Chaired the conference that led to the adoption of the **UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS)**, the 'Constitution for the Oceans.'



RUNA KHAN (BANGLADESH)



- **Social Entrepreneur** (Age: 67)
- Received the award for work among **Disadvantaged Communities**.
- **Friendship Bangladesh** (Founded 2002): Focused areas:
 - **Climate Resilience**
 - **Education**
 - **Women Empowerment**
 - **Livelihood Generation**
 - **Social Justice for Marginalized Groups**



BO KYI (MYANMAR)



- **Human Rights Activist** (Age: 61)
- Honored for lifelong resistance against **Military Repression** and **Human Rights Violations**.
- **Assistance Association for Political Prisoners (AAPP)** (Co-founded 2000): Documents political imprisonment and supports detainees and their families.



Read More: [Ramon Magsaysay Award 2025](#)

Aranmula Uthrattathi Boat Race



Source: TH

The **Aranmula Uthrattathi Vallamkali (boat race)** is one of Kerala's most iconic traditional events, symbolising the State's cultural heritage, devotion and community spirit. Aranmula is a heritage village located on the banks of the **Pamba River** and is famous for the **GI-tagged Aranmula Kannadi (metal mirror)** , a unique traditional craft of Kerala.

- **About the Event:** The **Aranmula Uthrittathi Vallamkali** is one of the **oldest traditional boat races of Kerala** . It is held annually on the day of the **Uthrittathi asterism in the Malayalam month of Chingam** (August–September) on the **Pamba River in Pathanamthitta district** .
- **Religious Significance:** The boat race is associated with the **Aranmula Sree Parthasarathy Temple** , dedicated to **Lord Krishna** . It is considered a **religious offering** and is conducted as part of the temple's traditions and **Onam celebrations** .
- **Legend Behind the Race:** According to tradition, the event originated when local snake boats came to protect the **Thiruvona Thoni** (boat carrying offerings for the Thiruvonam feast at the temple) from attackers. The incident symbolises **community unity, devotion, and collective protection of traditions** .
- **Palliyodams (Sacred Snake Boats):** The boats used in the race are known as **Palliyodams** . Unlike ordinary snake boats, they are taller and uniquely designed, with elaborate decorations. More than **100 oarsmen** row these boats in perfect coordination, accompanied by traditional boat songs (**Vanchippattu**).
- **Cultural Heritage:** The race showcases Kerala's traditional **boat-making skills, performing arts, music, and community participation** . Traditional songs such as **Kuchelavritam, Bheeshmaparvam, and Santhanagopalam** are associated with the event.



Read More: [Vembanad Lake: Kerala](#)